

David Tu

Prof. Benjamin Haber

SOC 266

Assignment 2: The Social Life of A.I

If I had to categorize my feelings toward A.I, I would divide my thoughts into two relatively distinct schools. On one hand, there is the leftist realist position, the orthodox Marxist in me which views the world as teleology and sees artificial intelligence as simply the next step in attaining the next highest stage of capital. I will admit this position lacks excitement. It's not subversive, but it's a tried and true method for anticipating the chaos wrought by speculative behavior. Historical materialists prides themselves on not really being surprised by anything, which certainly takes a level of confidence or audacity. Consequently, this assuredness can blind us to the ways that A.I is transforming the landscape. It is on this note that I point to the other school of thought. This side of me is more akin to the preachings of the New Left. It regards the lifeblood of society not so much through political economy, but through culture. This is the side which sees the malaise of A.I psychosis and dreads the possibility of future generations being raised by A.I. That being said, this perspective's most glaring weakness is the lack of empirical or *scientific* evidence (a la Marx) compared to the old philosophy. It necessarily makes the argument that this is a unique point in history, which isn't always the case. In this paper, I hope to strike a balance between the two while speaking to the multifaceted impacts of A.I.

The strongest case for the realist position lies in the inseparable link between finance capital and artificial intelligence today. While whispers mount of the possibility of an "A.I bubble", the realist is completely incredulous. "Of course it is a bubble!" they might say. "What

else could it possibly be?” This argument traces a direct line from the advent of capital to more traditional forms of speculation such as private equity and real estate to what I now consider the era of digitized speculation: cryptocurrency, non-fungible tokens (NFTs), and finally A.I. Luckily for me, you even don’t need to be a progressive critic to push the bubble line. In fact, some of the most involved figures plainly admit the risky nature of A.I investments and only hope to maximize their gains. In a *Financial Times* opinion piece titled “A.I bubble: don’t throw the baby out with the bathwater”, Simon Edelsten openly states that it’s not a matter of *if* a bubble has formed, but a question of *when* the bubble will pop. When comparing the events today to the 2000s NASDAQ crash, Edelsten’s motivations shine especially when he writes before the bubble burst in March 2000, “investors had a good six months to take their profits before the bear market really took hold.” He follows this up with what I perceive to be an extensive “escape plan” in the inevitable outcome of a crash; alternative stock options, market observation advice, a study which highlights investor preference for Amazon and Google.

What immediately stands out to me in this piece is the objectivity, while rooted in maximizing financial gain, is in some ways akin to a leftist criticism of A.I. For example, Edelsten makes a descriptive critique of the Magnificent Seven technology companies. While he admits their undeniable power in global wealth systems, he interestingly shares the same concerns of a number of progressive commentators. The biggest standout is the grasp these companies have on “global equity indices.” In other words, much of the U.S and global economy is being propped up by the money that goes into these massive A.I data centers. Even as economies supposedly grow at astounding rates, the money generated has little velocity or liquidity. It doesn’t amount to any new discernable goods or services for the average person. Furthermore, the relationship amongst all these A.I companies can only be described as

“incestuous.” Capital is passed back and forth among three or four major collaborators and generates the speculative hype which attracts investors. It makes me think to the sycophant environments of crypto as described by Zeke Faux in *Number Go Up: Inside Crypto's Wild Rise and Staggering Fall*. On that note, at the end of Edelsten's article, there is a note describing his position: “a fund manager at Goshawk Asset Management. Goshawk funds own Microsoft, Amazon, Alibaba, Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co, Nestle and Schlumberger. To me, this read a lot closer to the finance old guard, the same group of Wall Street patriarchs who often clashed with the Californian ideology prophets of the tech space in *Number Go Up*. All of this begs the question of whether or not A.I really is the next big frontier or a continuation of a trend long prophesized by progressive pundits.

Moving to the perversive side of A.I, I can't think of a more perversive contributor to the topic than the Slovenian philosopher and cultural critic Slavoj Zizek. Though undoubtedly influenced by Marx, Zizek was more influenced by the young Hegelian Marx as opposed to the later economist who wrote *Das Kapital*. These cultural machinations led Zizek in finding his greatest critiques of society through mediums such as film (this was the case in his documentary, “The Pervert's Guide to Ideology”) as well as music. As such, I found an article on his Substack that very much keeps with this trend, “Why We Remain Alive Also In a Dead Internet”. The “dead internet” passage is very similar to Jonathan Frankle's description of the “boring apocalypse” as outlined in Ezra Klein's NYT opinion piece. Likewise, Zizek writes that “an author uses ChatGPT to write an academic essay and submits it to a journal, which uses ChatGPT to review the essay... a reader again uses ChatGPT to read the essay and provide a brief summary for them...” Of course, it wouldn't be Zizek unless he precluded this analogy with another one comparing bot-to-bot interactions to the “ideal” sexual act involving two lovers and

their electric dildo and electric vaginal opening. Something to do with the automating of the superego's duty.

Yet somehow, this is not the most deviant opinion Zizek has on A.I in this Substack piece. Further down, Zizek's love for film shines through when he questions the intended social lessons of *The Matrix* franchise. He does this by actually rejecting the proposed solution of one Geoffrey Stanton, a Nobel Prize-winning computer scientist and former Google exec. Stanton believed that people needed to work around the possibility of A.I surpassing human capabilities by building "maternal instincts" into the model. That way, the systems really would care for people once they became smarter than humans (Zizek). In many ways, this approach has already garnered interest. The takeaway in class after reading Burrell's "How the machine thinks" and Anthropic Co.'s "Mapping the Mind of a Large Language Model" was that some found it okay if A.I algorithms remained opaque as long as they worked for humanity's betterment. The specific terminology we used was ChatGPT's "forever baby." However, the point is that Zizek didn't buy into this claim. He writes that the original purpose of the Matrix was to keep humans happy in a pre-natal state. Agent Smith, who Zizek posits as the Freudian psychoanalyst detached from humanity, openly shares this information. The crux is that the system failed because humans kept trying to wake from this perfect world. They were drawn to a reality filled with suffering and misery and the Matrix reflected that. The takeaway is that not only do imperfections in A.I. derive from imperfections in humanity (what Stanton was trying to address), but that humanity's own failings would be grounded in A.I's inability to function without relying on human energy. It is a strange yet powerful assertion of human perseverance, rooted in what is typically considered a weakness – Lacan's thesis on the big Other's (A.I in this case) need for "constant jouissance" (Zizek).

Continuing, if the moral of the story is that without humans, machines would cease function, then there surely must be other applications. As Zizek is an enjoyer of “the arts”, I find the topic of A.I art to be the perfect closer to this journey. While I was unable to find anything from Zizek himself, I came across an excellent Guardian piece by political anthropologist Eric Reinhart. In “The trouble with A.I art isn’t just lack of originality. It’s something far bigger”, the “bigger” trouble in question draws on the work of the critical theorist Walter Benjamin. Reinhart explains that in Benjamin’s “The Work of Art in the Age of Technological Reproducibility”, it was only art that could politicize the aesthetic. Fascism, which was on everyone’s mind at the time, could only aestheticize the political. Here, Reinhart draws a direct line from the latter case to the A.I art craze today. He claims not only is there empirical evidence linking politically Right groups to an interest in A.I art, he believes the relationship between the two is cemented at an ideological level.

Elon Musk has sort of become the zeitgeist to this argument; a tech billionaire whose proximity to both establishment Republicans and the fringes of the online alternative Right has culminated in the purchasing and subsequent rebranding of Twitter/X. To what exactly? Reinhart loops things back to the fascist fantasy of society. Musk claims to be a champion of free speech and thought. In reality, he aims to construct an echo chamber which censors any and all his dissidents. By comparison, Hitler espoused visions of an artistically rich Nazi Germany. The problem was that where art was meant to evoke curiosity, fascism demanded absolute obedience. It is for that reason that the only “art” tolerated was created entirely by and for the regime. Everything else was considered “degenerate.” A.I art, writes Reinhart, is the greatest thing the fascists could have wished for because it generates visuals based on prompts. It is entirely for the machinations of the prompter, and it leaves no room for interpretation.